Reception and asked for a doctor to come to my room but were told that there wasn't one available at that hour. I asked where the nearest hospital was and went there immediately. After a brief examination, I was given a lotion for the night and was asked to come back the following morning.

We got a taxi from the hospital and after a few minutes the driver said to me in Hindi, '*Aap wohi ho jo main samaj raha hoon.*' (I think you are the person I think you are.) I admitted that I was and he offered to show us around Sydney, which I was in no mood to do. I asked him if he wouldn't mind taking us to a fast-food place instead and Anjali got out to get some burgers for dinner while I waited in the cab. The driver accompanied her and when they returned she told me that he had insisted on paying for the food. He also refused to take any money from us after dropping us off at the hotel and left his number in case we needed to go anywhere else in Sydney during our stay. I was very touched by the gesture and told him that I would leave match tickets for him at Reception. Later I got one of my Test shirts signed by the team and left it with the tickets.

I returned to the hospital the following morning and asked the doctor to do whatever he thought necessary to give me some quick relief, as I had a Test match to play the following morning. The doctor was a little taken aback, considering my condition, but I was absolutely determined to play. That afternoon we were supposed to be practising but I was in no state to stay out in the sun. I ended up batting against my dear friend Subroto Banerjee, the former India medium-fast bowler, who was then a resident of Sydney, in the indoor nets for a good forty-five minutes. I managed to take the field the next day, however, and that was the first time I wore a floppy white hat, which from then on became my trademark on the field. I applied a lot of ice to my face and then plastered it with zinc cream. It looked ridiculous but that didn't bother me.

After a couple of days, it finally started to settle down and I looked almost human again.

Second Test, Sydney, 2–6 January 2008

We suffered a blow on the eve of the Sydney Test when Zaheer was forced to return to India with a heel injury. Someone's loss is always another person's gain, however, and Zaheer's return meant young Ishant Sharma would get an opportunity to play in Australia for the first time.